'And,' the critics chorused, 'when will they learn AB should not keep wicket in Tests because his technique is not sound enough and the added responsibility obviously affects his batting?'

My position on the wicketkeeping issue remained the same. It was not something I particularly wanted to do but, as far as I was concerned, my personal preference was secondary. If the coach and captain believed it was something I should do to assist the balance of the squad, then I was perfectly prepared to do the job; and the more the experts said I couldn't handle both roles, the harder I tried to prove them wrong.

In the first Test against Pakistan at the Wanderers, I held six catches as the tourists were bowled out for 49, and then took that to a total of 11 dismissals in the match, equalling the world record for a wicketkeeper set by Jack Russell, of England, at the same venue in 1995. I then scored 103 not out in our second innings, becoming the first player to claim more than 10 dismissals and make a century in the same Test match.

Of greater significance, Dale took 11 wickets and we won the first Test by 211 runs. Our excellent form produced a close-fought win in Cape Town and a convincing victory in Pretoria, and we took the series 3–0. For me, the runs were starting to flow again: 61 and 36 at Newlands were followed by 121 at SuperSport Park.

Keep in mind the 'R' in REPS, I told myself: 'Recognise the thin line between success and failure.' Remember that it's just as important when things are going well as it is when they're not going so well.

These were good times. The Pakistan team included talented players such as Younus Khan, a world-class batsman I always enjoyed watching, and Saeed Ajmal, one of the most skilful right-arm off-break bowlers I ever faced, but I managed to produce innings of 65, 4, 128, 75 and 95 not out in the ODI series and we fought hard as a team, going 1–0 up, losing, going 2–1 up, losing and then winning the deciding match in Benoni.

In excellent spirits, our squad flew north to compete in yet another